

SNOWBE ONLINE Policy# SPM-01

Software Patch Management

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Software Patch Management – Version 1.0

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Purpose

This policy establishes SnowBe Online's requirements for managing software patches across all systems to reduce security vulnerabilities and maintain system integrity, availability, and reliability. The policy defines how patches are identified, evaluated, tested, approved, deployed, and verified to ensure consistent and controlled updates across the organization. It ensures that security updates are applied in a timely manner to protect customer data, payment processing systems, and business operations from known threats and exploitation. This policy supports SnowBe's overall risk management strategy by enforcing a structured and repeatable approach to maintaining secure and up-to-date systems across both cloud and on-premise environments.

Scope

This policy applies to all SnowBe employees, contractors, consultants, system administrators, developers, engineers, and third-party providers responsible for managing or maintaining software and systems. It includes all environments and assets owned, operated, or managed by SnowBe, including AWS-hosted systems, on-premise servers, network devices, desktops, laptops, retail systems, applications, and supporting infrastructure. This policy applies to all software components, including operating systems, applications, firmware, and third-party tools that store, process, transmit, or protect company, customer, employee, vendor, or payment-related information. It also applies to systems in development, testing, production, and maintenance phases, as well as systems integrated with external vendors or service providers.

Definitions

Critical Patch

A patch that addresses actively exploited vulnerabilities or high-risk security issues requiring immediate remediation.

Maintenance Window

A scheduled period during which system updates and changes can be applied with minimal disruption to operations.

Patch

A software update designed to correct vulnerabilities, fix defects, or improve system functionality and performance.

Patch Management

The process of identifying, prioritizing, testing, approving, deploying, and verifying software updates across systems.

Vulnerability

A weakness in a system that can be exploited to compromise confidentiality, integrity, or availability.

Roles & Responsibilities

Chief Information Security Officer (CISO)

Provides oversight of the patch management program, ensures alignment with organizational risk tolerance, and approves high-risk exceptions or deviations from policy.

Developer

Ensures internally developed applications and code dependencies are updated, tested, and remediated for known vulnerabilities.

Operations Department

Coordinates deployment schedules, ensures system availability, validates backups prior to updates, and supports recovery if issues occur during patching.

System Administrator

Identifies available patches, performs testing, deploys updates, verifies successful installation, and ensures systems remain compliant with patching requirements.

System Owner

Approves patching timelines, ensures business requirements are considered, and accepts risk when patching delays or exceptions are necessary.

Vendor

Provides timely updates, security advisories, and patches for supported systems and services and ensures alignment with SnowBe security expectations.

Policy

SnowBe Online shall implement a formal patch management process to ensure all systems are protected against known vulnerabilities. Patch management must be continuous, risk-based, and applied across all systems unless formally exempted. All systems must be monitored for new patches using vendor notifications, automated tools, and vulnerability management processes.

Patches must be evaluated based on severity, exploitability, and business impact, with priority given to critical and high-risk updates. Patches must be tested prior to deployment when feasible to ensure compatibility and stability. Where testing is limited, risk-based decisions must be documented and approved

before deployment. Patch deployment must follow established change management procedures and include proper scheduling, communication, and documentation. Maintenance windows should be used when appropriate to minimize disruption, and backups must be completed prior to deployment to support system recovery if needed.

After deployment, systems must be validated to confirm successful installation and continued operation. Failed or incomplete patches must be remediated promptly. Systems that cannot be patched must implement compensating controls and follow the formal exception process with documented justification and defined timelines for remediation.

Exceptions/Exemptions

Requests for exceptions must be submitted in writing to SnowBe Online's IT Security Manager for review and approval. Each request must include the business justification, defined scope, duration, and any compensating controls that will be applied. All approved exceptions will be formally documented, reviewed periodically for continued appropriateness, and remain valid for no longer than one year unless re-evaluated and re-approved.

Enforcement

Failure to follow this policy may result in disciplinary action, beginning with a verbal warning and escalating to written notice, suspension of system access, or termination of employment. Contractors and vendors who violate SnowBe Online's security or compliance requirements may have their access revoked or contracts terminated. Intentional or severe violations, especially those involving customer data or payment systems, may lead to termination and potential legal or regulatory action under applicable laws.

Version History Table

Version #	Implementation Date	Document Owner	Approved By	Description
1.0	03/29/2026	Jarred Ward	IT Security Manager	Original Draft

Citations

County of San Mateo - <https://www.smcgov.org/hr/virus-protection-and-patch-management-policy> (Used for Purpose, Scope, Policy).

Fordham University - <https://www.fordham.edu/information-technology/it-security--assurance/it-policies-procedures-and-guidelines/patch-management-policy/> (Used for Definitions, Exceptions/Exemptions).

Saint Mary's College of California. - <https://www.stmarys-ca.edu/sites/default/files/2024-04/SMC-Patch-Management-Policy.pdf> (Used for Roles & Responsibilities, Enforcement).